for a year to allow the new government, post-election in mid-2009, to make a choice on the successor. Occasionally, my name too would appear on some journalist's panel, which meant nothing beyond inquiries from my friends and colleagues to ask if it was true, and if I had indeed been sounded for the job by the prime minister or the finance minister.

I found all the speculation about being a possible candidate for the governor's job either irritating or amusing depending on my mood. To be honest, the question of whether I had the profile and experience to be the governor would occasionally cross my mind. True, compared to many of my civil service colleagues, I had long experience in public finance management, both at the state and central government levels, if only because of accident and luck in postings. My CV was also burnished by international experience at the World Bank for over five years. But all this was mostly on the fiscal side—not the main focus of central banking. Because I thought there were others who fit the bill better, I was quite dismissive of all the kite-flying by the media.

I had known Rakesh Mohan, deputy governor in the Reserve Bank, for several years—which in itself should not be surprising if only because there are few people that Rakesh does not know. That acquaintance grew into a warm friendship over the previous year because of the regular professional interaction entailed by our respective jobs. Over this period, I had grown to respect Rakesh's intelligence, competence and maturity, and agreed with the widely shared view that he was a shoo-in for the governor's job. In an informal conversation, Y.V. Reddy once told me that it had been a standard convention for the government to consult the outgoing governor on the choice of his successor, and should that convention be followed, he would certainly recommend Rakesh's name.

On 24 August 2008, Rakesh who was in the United States, attending the annual Jackson Hole Conference of central banks, called me up to say that he had got a call from the finance minister's office asking him to come and meet the minister in Delhi later that week. He asked me if I knew what it was about. I didn't, but my hunch was that P. Chidambaram was calling Rakesh to personally convey his appointment as governor before releasing